



August 13, 2026

RFK Campus Master Plan Project Team
District of Columbia Office of Planning
OP.RFKMasterPlan@dc.gov

Re: Public comment on the RFK Campus Master Plan public comment draft

Dear Members of the Project Team,

As Chair of the Multimodal Accessibility Advisory Council, established under D.C. Official Code § 50–2361.31, I am writing to comment on the accessible transportation elements of the RFK Campus Master Plan public comment draft.

Because the comment period closes before the Council's next meeting, I submit these comments in my individual capacity as Chair, not as a position adopted by a vote of the Council. The Principles for Arterial Street Space Usage cited below were adopted unanimously by the Council in February 2025.

The RFK campus is the largest piece of undeveloped, publicly controlled land in the District. Almost everything else MAAC works on is a retrofit. We are asking a city to undo choices made fifty years ago, one block at a time, against the constraint of a curb that is already fully allocated. RFK is the rare case where the District is not repairing a street but writing one from nothing. What gets drawn now will govern how a disabled resident reaches this campus for the next half century, and it will be far more expensive to fix later than to get right in the first attempt.

My position on parking

I ask that the master plan commit to no general-purpose car parking serving the Gold Line station area or the campus core.

In February 2025 this Council unanimously adopted Principles for Arterial Street Space Usage in Washington, DC. That document ranks eleven uses of public street space in priority order. Truly market-priced car parking is eleventh – the last priority, below tree boxes and green space. ADA pick-up/drop-off zones are third, behind only accessible sidewalks and dedicated transit lanes. A plan that allocates land to general parking at a site built around bus rapid transit inverts that order on the one site where the District has a free hand.

I want to be precise about what I am and am not asking for, because the phrase is easily misread:

- **No** general-purpose, commuter, or event parking supply at the Gold Line station area or the campus core, and no minimum parking requirements in the recommended zoning for those districts.
- **Yes** to ADA-designated parking, at or above the ratio the ADA requires, sited closer to entrances than any other vehicle accommodation on the campus.
- **Yes** to ADA pick-up/drop-off zones, designed and built from the start.

Those are not in tension. Parking supply and accessible access compete for the same land, and the way accessible access loses that competition is by being treated as a subset of parking rather than as its own requirement. Every general space built near an entrance is a space an accessible vehicle

cannot use.

ADA pick-up/drop-off must be designed in, not retrofitted

Most trips by disabled residents to a site like this one will arrive by paratransit van, taxi, or rideshare, not by a private car parked for the day. A vehicle serving those trips needs a place to stop at the curb, level, out of the travel lane, with an access aisle beside it so a side-loading (or rear-loading) ramp can deploy.

The District's record on this is the reason I raise it here. In March 2026 MAAC wrote to DDOT asking for a block-by-block audit of accessible pick-up/drop-off zones in the downtown core. The reason that audit matters is that the District cannot presently say how many such zones exist. It publishes no count. We know there are roughly 150,000 residential permit spaces, 20,000 metered spaces, 1,400 commercial loading zones, and 600 diplomatic spaces. The figure for disabled residents is unknown.

That is what happens when accessible loading is left to be worked out after the street network is set. I am asking the Office of Planning not to repeat it here. Specifically:

- Name accessible pick-up/drop-off as a required curb use in the master plan text, at every major destination on the campus – the stadium, the Gold Line station, the retail and housing districts, and the recreation and open space areas.
- Set a numeric target for accessible pick-up/drop-off zones in the plan itself, so that the count is a design input rather than something to be discovered later.
- Require an access aisle and a level landing at each zone. A painted space at the curb with a car parked tight against it is not usable by a side-loading vehicle.

What I support

I support the Gold Line bus rapid transit connection and ask that it be delivered in time for the stadium opening. I support the draft plan's proposed bike network, built to the fully protected standard that moveDC already specifies, and I support extending protected bikeways across the Anacostia into Wards 7 and 8. I join the Washington Area Bicyclist Association in asking that Metrorail improvements at Stadium-Armory be reconsidered rather than treated as settled.

I would add one thing to that list. Accessible sidewalks with ADA-compliant ramps, on both sides of every street and free of obstruction, are the first priority in the Council's adopted principles and the precondition for all of the above, as are crosswalks that are safe for disabled pedestrians and built with audible signals. A protected bikeway and a BRT station are both reached on foot or by wheelchair.

Request

I ask that the final master plan reflect these comments, and I ask to be consulted as the transportation and public space elements advance to detailed design. MAAC is a statutory body, and I would welcome the chance to review specifics rather than comment only at the plan stage. The Council's adopted principles document is attached, and I am happy to discuss any of this with the team.

Sincerely,

Karthik Balasubramanian
Chair, Multimodal Accessibility Advisory Council
info@maacdc.org

Submitted in my individual capacity as Chair. Not a position adopted by a vote of the Council.

Attached: MAAC Principles for Arterial Street Space Usage in Washington, DC (adopted February 12, 2025) – maacdc.link/principles